# For Black Boys -- A Collection

## By Jasmine Mans, Margaret Burroughs and Keith Antar Mason

## INTRODUCTION

*On July 12, 1967, rumors spread that police had killed a black man in Newark, NJ. Though the story was untrue — the man was beaten but survived — pent-up rage led to four nights of riots and looting.*

*50+ years have passed, and the words by Jasmine Mans in tribute to the Newark riots still ring true for many people of color. In recent years, fatal shootings of unarmed black men across the United States have sparked outrage and concerns over police use of lethal force.*

*For Black Boys – A Collection with poems by Jasmine Mans, Margaret Burroughs and Keith Antar Mason*

### Ode To Newark by Jasmine Mans

**(Pg 12-13)** Blood has decorated these streets

They have begun to look like pastures of rose petals,

Black boys have gotten so fed up with their prayers

drowning by bedside,

The load their guns into the sky

To make sure God is listening

We are chalk outlines of snow angels,

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We breathe like death is lurking on the edge of our spleens

We dance in the wind to the crackles of gun shells,

Jerk bodies back like God is head puppeteer of this destruction

Our voices bend and crack in the wind between fear and park swings.

There is a guardian angel that lost the directions to salvation,

A Mother who clasped the New Testament too tight

For the heavens to take responsibility.

There is a God who choked on promises,

A Jesus who did not die for enough of them.

If Newark were a woman,

She would be Lauryn Hill after Zion,

With a broken spleen and body bags

Lying under her eyelids.

Death looks too much like children

Who slipped pass God's peripheral,

Maybe some of us are too premature for a tomorrow.

Maybe we've been dancing on the edge

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Of God's sanity for too long.

Some casualties of genocide look too familiar

To not scream.

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Jasmine Mans***
***Book: Chalk Outlines of Snow Angels, Pgs 12-13***
***ASIN: BOO8JHIM2Y (Digital Publication)***
***Publisher: Thorn 10 Publishing***
***Date (Month/Year): 2011***

## TRANSITION

*"The more things change, the more they stay the same." People of color continue to encounter overt and subtle racism, glass ceilings in the workplace and employers who are surprised to learn they hired competent, skilled black employees. Black men are still fearful when pulled over in a routine traffic stop. And words penned in the 1960's still ring true.*

*What Shall I Tell My Children Who are Black? by Margaret Burroughs*

## What Shall I Tell My Children Who Are Black? by Margaret Burroughs

What shall I tell my children who are black

Of what it means to be a captive in this dark skin

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What shall I tell my dear one, fruit of my womb,

Of how beautiful they are when everywhere they turn

They are faced with abhorrence of everything that is black.

Villains are black with black hearts.

A black cow gives no milk. A black hen lays no eggs.

Bad news comes bordered in black, black is evil

And evil is black and devils' food is black. . .

What shall I tell my dear ones raised in a white world

A place where white has been made to represent

All that is good and pure and fine and decent.

Where clouds are white, and dolls, and heaven

Surely is a white, white place with angels

Robed in white, and cotton candy and ice cream

and milk and ruffled Sunday dresses

And dream houses and long sleek cadillacs

And angel's food is white. . . all, all. . . white.

What can I say therefore, when my child

Comes home in tears because a playmate

Has called him black, big lipped, flatnosed

and nappy headed? What will he think

When I dry his tears and whisper, "Yes, that's true.
But no less beautiful and dear."
How shall I lift up his head, get him to square
His shoulders, look his adversaries in the eye,
Confident of the knowledge of his worth,
Serene under his sable skin and proud of his own beauty?

What can I do to give him strength
That he may come through life's adversities
As a whole human being unwarped and human in a world
Of biased laws and inhuman practices, that he might
Survive. And survive he must! For who knows?
Perhaps this black child here bears the genius
To discover the cure for. . . Cancer
Or to chart the course for exploration of the universe.
So, he must survive for the good of all humanity.
He must and will survive.
I have drunk deeply of late from the foundation
Of my black culture, sat at the knee and learned
From Mother Africa, discovered the truth of my heritage,
The truth, so often obscured and omitted.
And I find I have much to say to my black children.

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I will lift up their heads in proud blackness
With the story of their fathers and their fathers
Fathers. And I shall take them into a way back time
of Kings and Queens who ruled the Nile,
And measured the stars and discovered the
Laws of mathematics. Upon whose backs have been built
The wealth of continents. I will tell him
This and more. And his heritage shall be his weapon
And his armor; will make him strong enough to win
Any battle he may face. And since this story is
Often obscured, I must sacrifice to find it
For my children, even as I sacrificed to feed,
Clothe and shelter them. So this I will do for them
If I love them. None will do it for me.
I must find the truth of heritage for myself
And pass it on to them. In years to come I believe
Because I have armed them with the truth, my children
And my children's children will venerate me.
For it is the truth that will make us free!

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Margaret Burroughs***
***On-Line Transcript***
***https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poems/146263/what-shall-i-tell-my-children-who-are-black-reflections-of-an-african-american-mother***
***Publisher: Poetry Foundation***
***Date (Month/Year): Originally Published 1968***

## AWARD HISTORY

***2003 National Qualifier***

### Black Son by Jasmine Mans

**(Pg 14-15)** How do you tell a Black woman that raising a

Black son

Isn't some type of inside joke

Crafted by God and some White man?

Can you prove to her that they are not in Heaven

Snickering at the soul of a single parent mother

Dressing her son for graduation

Hoping he can make it

Across the stage,

Down the aisle,

Or off the balcony quick enough

To not be caught in his skin

At the wrong time

I've touched the bellies of women

Who aborted more Black boys

Than thrown overboard slaves

Who will look you in the eyes

Like a blue bird awakening to a holocaust

And whisper

"I am just afraid to raise a Black son."

A Black boy is just a trembling soul

Suffocating in a fabric

That anyways itched around the neck

A tag that always seem to make you scratch

Around the noose collar

How can you tell a mother staring

At her newborn in the delivery room

Hoping that his skin doesn't get any darker

Praying it will stay as light and deceiving

As a sunrise in the ghetto

That her son's body isn't a chamber

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For some bigot

To hang his sin and southern accent in

That her baby's flesh isn't some colored toy

For the rich blue eyed boys

Can you tell a mother that her son isn't the disaster

Lurking in the back of master's mind

Before he prays over Sunday dinner

"I am just afraid to raise a black son"

Who will spend the rest of his life

Praying for a melody or a melanin

Safe enough to scream in

A boy who had to be a martyr for a war

He never asked for

Loving something so disposable

Never sat well in the pockets or hearts

Of mothers hoping for a break

And a teaspoon of sugar on this land

Son, you have been dancing in the hurricane too long.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Jasmine Mans***
***Book: Chalk Outlines of Snow Angels, Pgs 14-15***
***ASIN: BOO8JHIM2Y (Digital Publication)***
***Publisher: Thorn 10 Publishing***
***Date (Month/Year): 2011***

### For Black Boys who Have Considered Homicide When the Streets Were too Much by Keith Antar Mason

*A young man speaks emotionally about how it feels to be Black in White America.*

**Brother #3:** **(Pg 194-196)** I must be mistaken

some monster

I know

I can tell by the way you look

at me

you tighten up

and never smile

like aggression can only

be symbolized

by me

like the male gender

and colored black means

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death carrier
potent poison
lethal
and I know
some how I know
I want to live
a long time but
I am gonna die
some obscene
joke
cuz' you clutch
yourself around me
hold back
all the good things
even precious smiles
from me
some how I know
I wuz' born to die
to die too soon
and I don't understand
and that's the confusion you see
that's the fear

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you feel
I am no more than
The stacked up
cemented
aggression
black tornado
come back from
oz no hell
born to die
and I mus' be
a zombie
walkin' the streets
the livin' dead
and my brain
the curse
of the male gender
colored black
colored black
with nappy hair

And you only feel
afraid

but I know

how fear kills

I know

I live it

standin'

on the corner

holdin' the wall

like a firin' squad

and some how I know

I wuz' born to die

a zombie

live or dead

the male gender

cursed

colored black

and too damn

aggressive

jus' by being born

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Keith Antar Mason***
***Book: Colored Contradictions: An Anthology of Contemporary African American Plays, Pgs 194-196***
***ISBN: 978-0452274976***
***Publisher: Plume***
***Date (Month/Year): Nov 1996***

## AWARD HISTORY

***IL State Qualifier***

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